iylock style

for Song Structure Notation

v20260410

<Preface>

I could not find a clearly organized system for song structure notation. So, I organized it for practical use. I developed this while using it in a local church band for two years. Now, there are no major issues in using it.

When I decided to make it public online, I realized that it needed a name so that people could easily find this document. Also, this notation is merely my own model and is not academic. A model needs to be continuously updated if necessary. I thought that required a name.

Therefore, to signify a commitment to continuous learning and development, I transliterated "iylock"—which I call the "iylock Mindset"—and used it as the name. Just as there are various citation styles such as APA, Chicago, and MLA, I consider my song structure notation to be one of many possible styles, and I describe it as a style.

The list of song sections and symbols followed multitracks.com exactly. The same applies to most dynamic cues. My contributions were to clarify the criteria for classifying sections in my own way, to divide parts in order to express the structure of sections for smooth communication within the band, and to establish notations for dynamic cues and section carryover.

I have identified areas that need modification and development, and I plan to continue developing them gradually.

iylock (April 10, 2026)
South Korea

<Preface>

P.S. 1: This document was translated from Korean using Google Translate and ChatGPT.

P.S. 2: iylock(아일학) is an abbreviation for “a student who knows absolutely nothing (아는 게 1도 없는 학생).” It reflects the idea that what we think we know is often incomplete, and that recognizing the limits of our knowledge (our circle of competence) is essential to learning and staying humble.

P.S. 3: The version history of this document is maintained here: https://github.com/iylock/iylock-style

Vocal sections (9)	
V	Verse
Pr	Pre-chorus
C	Chorus
Po	Post-chorus
Rf	Refrain
B	Bridge
Tg	Tag
Ac	Acapella
Rp	Rap

Instrumental sections (9)	
I	Intro
It	Interlude
Ta	Turnaround
Is	Instrumental
S	Solo
Vp	Vamp
Bd	Breakdown
O	Outro
E	Ending

Dynamic cues (9)	
Bk	Break
Bd	Breakdown
Bu	Build Up
Ht	Half-time
Ku	Key change Up
Kd	Key change Down
Ac	Acapella
slow	Slow
big	Big Ending

<Vocal sections>

Symbol	Terms	Description
V	Verse	When there are multiple verses, the melody can be slightly varied or the mood can change.
Pr	Pre-chorus	A section before the chorus that leads into it.
C	Chorus	Chorus
Po	Post-chorus	A section that follows the chorus and develops the feel of the chorus.
Rf	Refrain	A section in which the same lyrics are repeated, which may be unrelated to the chorus's feel.
B	Bridge	A section where the overall mood of the song changes.
Tg	Tag	A section that takes a portion of a section—e.g., 4 bars from an 8-bar chorus.
Ac	Acapella	Vocal-Only Section, though some rhythmic or harmonic elements may be included.
Rp	Rap	Rap section

Difference between Refrain and Post-Chorus

A refrain is a section in which the same lyrics are repeated. However, a post-chorus may also repeat the same lyrics. If a section repeats the same lyrics, the distinction depends on whether it develops the chorus's image, feel, or musical ideas. If it does, it is considered a post-chorus; if it does not, it is considered a refrain. In cases where there are two sections in a song that repeat the same lyrics and both seem to develop the chorus's musical ideas, the section immediately following the chorus should be considered the post-chorus.

<Instrumental sections>

Symbol	Terms	Description
I	Intro	Intro
It	Interlude	A short 1–2 bar section connecting two sections.
Ta	Turnaround	A section that returns from the chorus to the verse, usually featuring the intro riff.
Is	Instrumental	A section in which only instruments are played.
S	Solo	A section where a specific instrument plays a solo.
Vp	Vamp	A section that repeats infinitely until the leader gives the signal to move on.
Bd	Breakdown	A section where the energy dramatically drops, often leaving only sustained notes from the instruments.
O	Outro	Outro
E	Ending	Song ends.

Detailed Explanation of Vamp

A Vamp is a section where a short loop is repeated continuously until the leader gives a cue. To put it more simply, it is a section where only the accompaniment is repeated infinitely until the singer enters. Examples of vamps include playing a chord progression like 1-4-1-4 repeatedly or continuously repeating the accompaniment of the next section.

When the section returning from the chorus to the verse is 1–2 bars long, is it a Turnaround or an Interlude?

If it simply feels like an extension of the chorus, it is considered an interlude. If it incorporates the song's main musical ideas, similar to the intro, it is considered a turnaround.

<Dynamic cues>

Symbol	Terms	Description
Bk	Break	Stop playing all instruments instantly.
Bd	Breakdown	Collapse the energy.
Bu	Build Up	Build up the energy.
Ht	Half-time	Play in half-time.
Ku	Key change Up	Transpose up.
Kd	Key change Down	Transpose down.
Ac	Acapella	Vocals only.
slow	Slow down	Ritardando.
big	Big Ending	Emphasize and sustain the first beat of the ending section.

Dynamic Cues Notation

Indicate the cues in parentheses before or after the section. Place the parentheses in a location that is easy to understand, following the flow of the section.

ex) (Bk)Pr, C(Bk), (Bd)C(Bu), C(Ac), C(slow), (Ku)Tg, E(big)

<Part>

A “part” is defined as a large grouping of sections within the overall section flow.

For example, consider the following section flow:
I – V1 – Pr – C – Ta – V1 – V2 – Pr – C – Vp – B – B – (Bd)C – C – O – E

If we divide this into parts, it can be organized as follows:
A : I – V1 – Pr – C –
A’: Ta – V1 – V2 – Pr – C –
B : Vp – B – B –
C : (Bd)C – C – O – E

Parts are labeled using uppercase letters in sequence, such as A, B, C, and so on, and are read as “Part A,” “Part B,” etc.

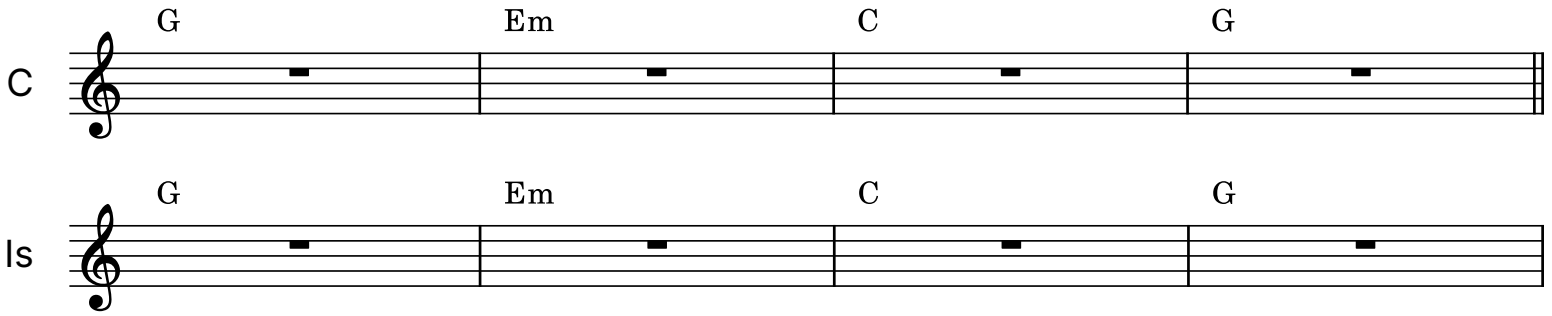
Using parts makes it possible to indicate section positions more clearly. For example, since V1 appears twice in the overall flow, referring to it as “V1 in Part A’” allows for unambiguous communication. When indicating a section within a specific part, it can be notated similarly to chapter and verse in the Bible, such as A:I or B:Vp.

The primary reason for dividing parts is to establish the overall dynamic of the song. Therefore, in a live performance, it is possible to return to any section within the same part or repeat the current section. However, once the progression moves to a new part, it is not possible to return to sections from a previous part.

<Section Carryover>

If a smooth transition between sections is intended, the next section begins within the last bar of the current section. An asterisk (*) is used to mark this.

For example, if the sections are as follows:



Then, depending on the (*) notation, the progression will be performed as shown below:



This notation can also be extended to two-bar units, for example in fast-tempo songs where each chord spans two bars in the score.

<Examples>

The following are examples:

퀸카 (Queencard) - (여자)아이들((G)I-DLE)
Welcome to the Show - DAY6
한 페이지가 될 수 있게 - DAY6
Ditto – NewJeans

What A Beautiful Name - Hillsong Worship
Wake - Hillsong Young & Free
Praise – Elevation Worship
Turn It Up – Planetshakers

주님은 아시네 – J-US
놀라우신 은혜 (This Is Amazing Grace) - 예수전도단 화요모임
I Will Run to You – 천관웅
모든 생명들아 소리쳐 – WELOVE

<Examples>

퀸카 (Queencard) – (여자)아이들((G)I-DLE) 〈I feel〉 (2023)

A : I – V1 – V2 – Pr – C – Po –
A’: It – V3 – Pr – C – Po – Rf – O – E

A :	I	V1	V2	Pr	C	Po		
Bars	4	8	8	8	8	8		

A' :	It	V3	Pr	C	Po	Rf	O	E
Bars	1	8	8	8	8	8	1	

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JuJBr9v6BGA

<Examples>

Welcome to the Show – DAY6 〈Fourever〉 (2024)

A : Vp – I – V1 – V2 – Pr1 – C1 – C2 –
A’: Ta – V3 – Pr2 – C1 – C2 –
B : B – It – C2 – C1 – C1(Ac) – E

A :	Vp	I	V1	V2	Pr1	C1	C2
Bars	2	4	8	8	8	8	8

A’ :	Ta	V3	Pr2	C1	C2		
Bars	2	8	8	8	8		

B :	B	It	C2	C1	C1(Ac)	E	
Bars	8	1	8	8	8		

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ViDjwX-yfgc

<Examples>

한 페이지가 될 수 있게 – DAY6 〈The Book of Us: Gravity〉 (2019)

A : I – V1 – V2 – Pr – It – C1 – C2 – Po –
A’: V3 – V4 – Pr – It – C1 – C2 –
B : B – C3 – C2 – Po – E

A :	I	V1	V2	Pr	It	C1	C2	Po
Bars	16	8	8	8	1	8	10	8

A’ :	V3	V4	Pr	It	C1	C2		
Bars	8	8	8	1	8	10		

B :	B	C3	C2	Po	E			
Bars	8	8	10	8				

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-9fC6oDFl5k

<Examples>

Ditto – NewJeans 〈NewJeans 'OMG'〉 (2023)

A : I – C1 – V1 – V2 – Pr1 – Pr2 – C1 – C2 –
A' : V3 – Pr2 – C1 – C2 – O – E

A :	I	C1	V1	V2	Pr1	Pr2	C1	C2
Bars	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8

A' :	V3	Pr2	C1	C2	O	E		
Bars	8	8	8	8	8			

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=V6TEcoNUmc8

<Examples>

What A Beautiful Name – Hillsong Worship 〈let there be light.〉 (2016)

A : Vp – V1 – C1 –
A’: It – V2 – C1 – Tg –
B : Vp – Is – B1 – B2 – B3 – B4 –
C : C2 – B3 – B4 – C2 – Tg – Tg – E

A :	Vp	V1	C1				
Bars	2	8	8				

A’ :	It	V2	C1	Tg			
Bars	1	8	8	2			

B :	Vp	Is	B1	B2	B3	B4	
Bars	8	4	4	4	4	4	

C :	C2	B3	B4	C2	Tg	Tg	E
Bars	8	4	4	8	2	2	

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H2T97r08MeU

<Examples>

Wake (Live) – Hillsong Young & Free 〈We Are Young & Free〉 (2013)

A : I – V1 – V2 – Pr – Is – C –
A’: Ta – V2 – Pr – Is – C –
B : Vp – B1 – B2 –
C : Pr – Is – C – O – E

A :	I	V1	V2	Pr	Is	C
Bars	8	8	8	8	8	8

A’ :	Ta	V2	Pr	Is	C	
Bars	8	8	8	8	8	

B :	Vp	B1	B2			
Bars	8	8	8			

C :	Pr	Is	C	O	E	
Bars	8	8	8	8		

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e33zCUm1ZnY

<Examples>

Praise – Elevation Worship 〈CAN YOU IMAGINE?〉 (2023)

A : I – Rf – V1 – V2 – Pr – C1 –
A’: V3 – V4 – Pr – C1 – C2 –
B : Vp – B – B –
C : (Bk)C1(Bu) – C1 – Tg – Tg – C2 –
D : Is – Rf – Rf – E

A :	I	Rf	V1	V2	Pr	C1
Bars	4	8	8	8	2	8

A’ :	V3	V4	Pr	C1	C2	
Bars	8	8	2	8	8	

B :	Vp	B	B			
Bars	8	8	8			

C :	C1	C1	Tg	Tg	C2	
Bars	8	8	4	4	8	

D :	Is	Rf	Rf	E		
Bars	8	8	8			

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=f2oxGYpuLkw

<Examples>

Turn It Up (Live) – Planetshakers 〈Endless Praise〉 (2014)

A : I – V1 – Pr – C –
A’: It – V2 – (Bk)Pr – C – C –
B : Is – Rf – Rf – B – (Ac)C(Bu) – C – E

A :	I	V1	Pr	C			
Bars	8	8	8	8			

A’ :	It	V2	Pr	C	C		
Bars	1	8	8	8	8		

B :	Is	Rf	Rf	B	C	C	E
Bars	4	8	8	8	8	8	

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gaOV-TH8G20

<Examples>

주님은 아시네 – J-US 〈The Beginning〉 (2014)

A : I – V1 – It – V2 – It – Pr – C –
A’: V1 – It – V2 – It – Pr – C – C –
B : Vp – Pr – Tg – It – C – C – E

A :	I	V1	It	V2	It	Pr	C
Bars	8	6	2	6	2	8	8

A’ :	V1	It	V2	It	Pr	C	C
Bars	6	2	6	2	8	8	8

B :	Vp	Pr	Tg	It	C	C	E
Bars	4	8	4	1	8	8	

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0gbxutEDm0M

<Examples>

놀라우신 은혜 (This Is Amazing Grace) – 예수전도단 화요모임 〈처음과 나중〉 (2017)

A : I – V1 – It – V2 – It – (bk)C –
A’: Ta – V3 – V4 – It – C –
B : Bd – B1 – B2 –
C : (Bk)C – It – C – O – E(big) –
D : Ac(C) – It – Ac(B1) – Tg – E

A :	I	V1	It	V2	It	C
Bars	8	6	2	6	2	14

A’ :	Ta	V3	V4	It	C	
Bars	4	6	6	2	14	

B :	Bd	B1	B2			
Bars	2	8	8			

C :	C	It	C	O	E	
Bars	14	2	14	8		

D :	Ac	It	Ac	Tg	E	
Bars	14	2	8	4		

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-x_rAdcUcZY

<Examples>

I Will Run to You – 천관웅 〈New Sound Worship〉 (2010)

A : Vp – I – V1 – V2 – C1 – C2 –
A’: V3 – V4 – C1 – C2 –
B : S – S – C1 – C2 – (Ku)C1 – C2 –
C : (Ku)(Bk)C1(Bk) – C2 – Rf – O – E

A :	Vp	I	V1	V2	C1	C2
Bars	2	8	8	8	8	8

A’ :	V3	V4	C1	C2		
Bars	8	8	8	8		

B :	S	S	C1	C2	C1	C2
Bars	8	8	8	8	8	8

C :	C1	C2	Rf	O	E	
Bars	8	8	8	8		

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fMZneBv52o8

<Examples>

모든 생명들아 소리쳐 – WELOVE 〈모든 생명들아 소리쳐〉 (2020)

A : I – V1 – V2* – It – C* –
A’: Ta – V3 – V4* – It – C – Rf(Bu) – Rf – (Bu)Rf* – It –
B : (Bd)V5* – It – Is – B – B – B(Bu) – It –
C : C – Rf(Bu) – Rf(Bk) – Tg(slow) – E(big)

A :	I	V1	V2	It	C				
Bars	8	4	3.5	2	7.5				

A’ :	Ta	V3	V4	It	C	Rf	Rf	Rf	It
Bars	4	4	3.5	2	8	4	4	3.5	2

B :	V5	It	Is	B	B	B	It		
Bars	3.5	2	4	4	4	4	1		

C :	C	Rf	Rf	Tg	E				
Bars	8	4	4	1.5					

Audio: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EjcYilVRI0w

<Notes>

- All bars are included when dividing sections without omission in order to ensure clear and unambiguous communication among team members.
- Document author: iylock (iylockgmail@gmail.com)

+ Section and Part Development History
  - **Section**: The list of song sections and symbols was adopted directly from MultiTracks.com, while my contribution was to establish my own criteria for classifying sections (May 2024, iylock).
  - **Part**: Developed based on the idea of chapters and verses in the Bible (May 2024, iylock).
  - **Dynamic Cues**: Most of the dynamic cue list was based on MultiTracks.com and further developed through performance experience (2024–2025, Jeong, iylock).
  - **Section Carryover Notation**: Established during rehearsal for the 2025 summer camp (2025, iylock, Jeong).

<References>

MultiTracks.com. (2019, February 18). *Updated song sections & guide cues!* [Blog post]. https://www.multitracks.com/blog/updated-song-sections-guide-cues (Accessed May 15, 2024)

MultiTracks.com. (n.d.). *Click & guide* [Audio files]. https://www.multitracks.com/free/. https://multitracks.blob.core.windows.net/public/content/free/Click_and_Guide_Samples.zip (Accessed May 15, 2024)

<Revision History>

+ v20250203 Initial release (internal only)

+ v20250703 Revised

  - Added: Parts; Dynamic Cues (Ku, Kd, slow only) and examples; song-by-song section division examples; notes; revision history; Added a prayer time example to the Vamp description

  - Fixed: Corrected an error where Breakdown was labeled as B; Removed duplicate explanation of “Big Ending” in Dynamic Cues

+ v20251225 Revised

  - Added: Explanation of the “*” section carryover notation → updated section labeling in <모든 생명들아 소리쳐>; Learning sequence explanation

  - Revised: Changed the part division example in <Part> from A~B to A~C

+ v20260410 Revised (public release)

  - Revised: Named the system “iylock style” for public online release; overall structural revision; added explanation that section carryover notation can be extended to two-bar units

  - Added: Preface

  - Removed: Vamp description; Learning sequence explanation